

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-06-10

1 beloved friends,
2 Twenty-five years have passed since the establishment of the interna-
3 tional Teaching center, during which time its structure, including that of
4 the institution of the continental boards of counselors, has been steadily
5 consolidated. The counselors and their auxiliaries have assumed their re-
6 sponsibilities for the protection and the propagation of the faith with in-
7 creasing vigor. Their role in the advancement of the cause, whether through
8 contacts with the individual believers or consultations with Assemblies, has
9 been crucial, and the animating influence of their institution can now be
10 felt in every area of bahá'í endeavor. The contributions they are making to
11 the execution of the four year plan are ample evidence of the maturation 271.1
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273 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan
274 627taking place. This impressive record stands as a testimony to the diligence
275 and wisdom with which the Teaching center has guided their efforts.

The enclosed overview of the duties assigned to your institution, ex-

276 pressed in broad terms, will provide the general framework for your opera-tions. The
focus of your work will, of course, be determined by the specific requirements of the f aith at
any given period in its development.

277 in the matter of protection, the current procedures for determining the

278 expulsion and reinstatement of covenant-breakers remain unchanged, and

279 you will continue to exercise the responsibility for evaluating the reports of the
counselors and submitting your decision in each case to us for our

280 consideration and approval before it is announced.

281 in recent years, opposition to the cause has taken forms unfamiliar to

282 the bahá'í community, and this poses new challenges to your institution.

283 you will have to take measures to help the counselors to develop, in col-
 284 laboration with National Spiritual Assemblies, the ability to detect these subtle
 attacks and to counter their negative influence. in this connection,
 285 their efforts to encourage promising young scholars and promote within the
 286 bahá'í community an appropriate appreciation of intellectual attainment
 287 will represent yet another invaluable service to the cause.
 288 in the field of propagation, during the first two years of this term, you
 289 need to center your energies on the prosecution of the four year plan. This
 290 is a decisive moment in the history of the world and in the fortunes of the
 291 faith, and it is apparent that the bahá'í community has become endowed
 292 with a new strength. The bahá'ís of the world have their eyes fixed on one
 293 single aim. in order to significantly advance the process of entry by troops,
 294 they have been asked to concentrate on the discharge of two immediate tasks: to
 multiply the human resources of the cause on an unprecedented
 295 scale and, in ever-increasing numbers, to devote themselves to teaching.
 296 Since the commencement of the p lan, the friends everywhere have been la-
 297 boring assiduously, acquiring the powers needed to accomplish these tasks.
 298 Through the imaginative use of the means at your disposal, you will be able to
 reinforce their exertions and ensure that they forge ahead with vision and
 299 resolve.
 300 To this end, it will be important for the Teaching center to keep care-
 301 ful watch over the progress being made worldwide, analyzing the situa-tion of the
 faith region by region and, if necessary, in specific countries.
 302 in this way, you can determine the extent to which the capacity of each
 303 national community to promote the process of entry by troops is be-272.2
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 273 m eS Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 274 628ing developed and exercised. you will be able to identify specific needs,
 275 for example, in the strengthening of institutes, in the implementation of

276 teaching projects, and in the production and distribution of literature,
277 and to respond to them by making recommendations to us, offering ad-vice to the
counselors, deploying pioneers and traveling teachers, and
278 disbursing financial resources.

Throughout the world, evidences multiply of a new energy at work in

279 the life of the cause. you have every reason to feel confident of the ability
280 of your institution to help the friends seize the extraordinary possibilities thus
opening before them. be sure of our ardent prayers that bahá'u'lláh will
281 confirm you in this great endeavor.

OVERVIEW OF DUTIES EXERCISED

BY THE INTERNATIONAL TEACHING CENTER

UNDER THE GUIDANCE OF THE

UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

282 • To exercise full responsibility for coordinating, stimulating and directing the
continental boards of counselors, acting also as

283 liaison between them and the universal house of justice.

• To be fully informed of the situation of the cause in all parts

284 to the continental boards of counselors.

285 • To watch over the security and ensure the protection of the faith of god. To
investigate all cases of incipient covenant-

breaking, employing, as necessary, the services of the continental

286 counselors and their auxiliaries. To evaluate the reports rendered by the continental
counselors and to decide whether the offender

should be expelled from the cause, submitting the decision to

with the hands of the cause of god, and approval before an

287 announcement is made. To follow a similar procedure for the reinstatement of a
contrite covenant-breaker.

288 • To be attentive to the spiritual health of the bahá'í community,

289 strengthening the believers to resist the influence of both internal and external
enemies and ensuring, to this end, that the continental

counselors assist National and local Spiritual Assemblies in 272.7

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274 629dealing with questions that cast doubt on the integrity of the faith

275 and its teachings.

• **To be alert to possibilities for the expansion of the faith, the consolidation of its institutions and the development of bahá'í community life, analyzing such possibilities in the context of global plans, fostering consultation among the believers and their institutions on the nature and methods of sustained processes**

276 of growth, anticipating needs worldwide, and ensuring that the necessary resources become available to national communities. To give particular attention to the development of human resources,

helping national communities increase their capacity to endow

277 growing contingents of believers with spiritual insights, knowledge of the faith, and skills and abilities of service.

• **To administer a budget provided from the bahá'í international**

fund, allocating therefrom monies for the development of insti-

278 tutes, the implementation of various types of teaching projects, and the production and distribution of literature and audiovisual

materials, as well as the operations of the continental boards of

counselors. To also administer the expenditure of the interna-

tional deputization fund and to see to it that pioneers and travel-

279 ing teachers are deployed in areas of need, with the help of the continental pioneer committees, whose work it directs.

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Reaching the Age of Spiritual Maturity

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]